

>> advice for beginners

When you start any new exercise program, it can be exhilarating and daunting at the same time. You obviously want to have fun as you progress through your dance workouts, but you also need to know how to work effectively and safely so that you will avoid injury.

Important points to think about before you begin to exercise are what clothing and equipment you will require; the space you will need; staying hydrated; correct breathing as you exercise; how frequently you should exercise; and how to practice safely. As a beginner to dance, you may also want to know a little about how dancers count the music.

Clothing and equipment

Proper exercise clothes will not only make you feel more comfortable while you are exercising, but can also prevent injury. Make sure your sneakers have

a sturdy sole and offer proper support around your ankle. Clothing should be comfortable and form-fitting and should be made out of a material that allows the skin to breathe. You want to avoid lots of zips, buttons, or flowing material. Zips and buttons can scratch, and excess material will get in the way while you are moving. The only piece of equipment you might need for these exercise programs is a comfortable, soft mat for the short, floor-based toning and stretching sections that end each workout. If you do not have a mat, you can use a folded blanket on the floor instead.

How much space do I need?

You will need to clear a small space in front of your television, computer, or DVD player so that you can follow along with the DVD. The space should be big enough to walk comfortably four steps forward and back and four steps side to side. Please make sure that there are no obstacles in the way that you could trip over or bump into as you are practicing.

The importance of staying hydrated

Staying hydrated while exercising is more important than most people realize. Whenever you are performing an aerobic activity that raises the body temperature over a sustained period of time, your

In order to avoid the effects of dehydration, such as headaches and cramping, take small sips of water before, during, and after exercising.

